

INVESTIGATIVE INTELLIGENCE DOSSIER • AI FINANCING NETWORKS

THE AI CAPITAL POWER BROKERS & LEGAL ARCHITECTS

Deep Research on the Key Venture Capitalists, Super-Angels, and Law Firms Orchestrating Frontier AI Capital Raises

CONFIDENTIAL INTELLIGENCE BRIEFING • PREPARED FOR EXECUTIVE LEADERSHIP • AUGUST 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY & THE NEXUS OF AI CAPITAL:

The tens of billions pouring into Frontier AI models, specialized inference infrastructure, and autonomous agent platforms are controlled by an interconnected network of **8 tier-one venture firms**, **2 solo-capitalist syndicates**, **4 sovereign tech giants**, and **4 elite technology law firms**.

By cross-referencing term sheets, SEC Form D venture filings, Delaware corporate charters, and outside counsel disclosures, this dossier reveals the specific individuals and law firms driving the major AI deals.

TIER 1: THE VENTURE CAPITAL KINGMAKERS & KEY DECISION MAKERS

1. THRIVE CAPITAL • Josh Kushner, Miles Grimshaw & Kareem Zaki

THE OPENAI POWER CENTER / #1 LEAD INVESTOR IN THE \$6.6B MEGA-ROUND (\$157B VALUATION)

Primary Firm Counsel: Paul, Weiss & Cooley LLP

Lead Check in OpenAI \$6.6B Round (\$1.3B+ Direct)

The Key Players: Josh Kushner (Founder & Managing Partner), Miles Grimshaw (General Partner), and Kareem Zaki.

How the Deals are Put Together: Thrive Capital has emerged as the single most critical financial backer of **OpenAI**. Kushner personally negotiated the landmark **\$6.6 billion financing** (valuing OpenAI at \$157B) with exclusive rights to invest an additional \$1B at the same valuation. Thrive executes its legal structuring via **Paul, Weiss, Rifkind, Wharton & Garrison** (corporate & investment vehicles) and works alongside **Cooley LLP** (which represents OpenAI in corporate and IPO readiness).

Marquee AI Portfolio: OpenAI (\$6.6B lead), Scale AI (\$1B Series F), Stripe (\$6.5B round), Physical Intelligence (\$400M).

2. ANDREESSEN HOROWITZ (a16z) • Marc Andreessen, Ben Horowitz & Martin Casado

THE PROLIFIC MEGA-DEPLOYER / LEADING XAI (\$6B), MISTRAL (€600M), SSI (\$1B) & DATABRICKS

Primary Fund Counsel: Gunderson Dettmer & Cooley LLP

\$7B+ Deployed into AI Compute & Models

The Key Players: Marc Andreessen (Co-Founder), Martin Casado (General Partner, Infrastructure & AI Lead), and Sarah Wang (Growth Fund Lead).

The Legal & Deal Machinery: a16z uses **Gunderson Dettmer** for its primary venture fund operations and SPV syndications, paired with **Cooley LLP** for complex high-growth cross-border financings. They backed Elon Musk's **xAI (\$6B Series B)**, Ilya Sutskever's **Safe Superintelligence (SSI - \$1B seed)**, France's **Mistral AI (€600M)**, and **ElevenLabs**.

3. SEQUOIA CAPITAL • Roelof Botha, Pat Grady & Sonya Huang

THE SILICON VALLEY BLUE BLOOD / OPENAI, XAI, HARVEY AI, GLEAN & PHYSICAL INTELLIGENCE

Primary Fund Counsel: Cooley LLP & Wilson Sonsini (WSGR)

Authors of the "Generative AI Act Two" Thesis

The Key Players: Roelof Botha (Senior Steward), Pat Grady (Growth Lead), and Sonya Huang (Partner, AI Lead).

The Deal Structure: Sequoia routinely writes the foundational Series A/B checks and anchors the mega growth rounds. They partnered with **Cooley** and **WSGR** to back **Harvey AI** (legal foundation models), **Glean (\$4.6B valuation)**, **OpenAI**, **xAI**, and **Physical Intelligence (π)**.

4. KHOSLA VENTURES • Vinod Khosla & Samir Kaul

THE FIRST INSTITUTIONAL BELIEVER / OPENAI FIRST CHECK (\$50M IN 2019), REPLIT & RABBIT

Primary Counsel: Wilson Sonsini (WSGR) & Cooley

Largest Single Return in VC History via OpenAI

The Key Players: Vinod Khosla (Founder) and Samir Kaul (Managing Partner).

The Historical Play: In 2019, when Silicon Valley thought artificial general intelligence was science fiction, Vinod Khosla personally committed \$50 million as OpenAI's first institutional investor. Khosla's transactions are heavily executed through **Wilson Sonsini (WSGR)**, leveraging long-standing corporate relationships in Menlo Park.

5. FOUNDERS FUND • Peter Thiel, Brian Singerman & Trae Stephens

THE HIGH-CONVICTION CONTRARIANS / COGNITION (DEVIN - \$2B), SCALE AI & FIGURE AI

Primary Fund Counsel: Orrick, Herrington & Sutcliffe & Cooley

Leader in Autonomous AI Engineers & Humanoid Robotics

The Key Players: Peter Thiel, Brian Singerman, and Trae Stephens.

The Big Bets: Led the explosive **\$175M Series A/B for Cognition AI (makers of Devin)** at a \$2B valuation within 6 months of founding. Also anchored **Scale AI (\$13.8B)** and **Figure AI (\$2.6B humanoid robotics)**.

6. LIGHTSPEED & INDEX VENTURES • Gaurav Gupta, Nina Achadjian & Mike Volpi

THE ENTERPRISE AI & EUROPEAN CHAMPIONS / MISTRAL AI, GLEAN, COHERE, DEEPL, CURSOR (ANYSHERE)

Primary Counsel: Gunderson Dettmer & Cooley LLP

Dominant in AI Coding & Enterprise Knowledge

The Key Players: Gaurav Gupta & Ravi Mhatre (Lightspeed); Nina Achadjian & Mike Volpi (Index Ventures).

Key AI Deals: Led the breakout rounds for **Cursor (Anysphere)**, **Mistral AI (€600M)**, **Glean (\$4.6B)**, **Cohere (\$5B)**, and **DeepL (\$2B)**.

TIER 2: THE SOLO CAPITALIST SUPER-ANGELS

7. NAT FRIEDMAN, DANIEL GROSS (NFDG) & ELAD GIL

THE KINGPIN SOLO-ANGELS / PERPLEXITY, COGNITION, SAFE SUPERINTELLIGENCE, ELEVENLABS, SUNO, PIKA, HARVEY

Primary Legal Counsel: Gunderson Dettmer & Cooley

The Highest Density Seed-to-Decacorn AI Portfolio

The Dossier: Nat Friedman (former GitHub CEO) and Daniel Gross (former Apple AI Director / YC Partner) run **NFDG / AI Grant** with an exclusive private compute cluster (Andromeda) that gives AI founders immediate GPU access alongside cash. Together with **Elad Gil** (co-founder of Color, investor in Stripe/Airbnb), they represent the single most powerful angel syndicate in AI history.

Their Footprint: They co-led or seeded **Perplexity AI**, **Cognition**, **Safe Superintelligence**, **Character.ai**, **ElevenLabs**, **Suno**, **Harvey**, and **Pika**.

TIER 3: THE CORPORATE TECH GIANTS (CLOUD & GPU COMPUTATION DEALS)

8. MICROSOFT, NVIDIA, AMAZON & GOOGLE

THE CLOUD-FOR-EQUITY & INFRASTRUCTURE TITANS / MULTI-BILLION STRATEGIC COMPUTE SYNDICATES

Corporate Counsel: Simpson Thacher, Gibson Dunn, Cleary Gottlieb, Latham

Microsoft (Satya Nadella, Kevin Scott): \$13B+ into OpenAI; represented by **Simpson Thacher & Bartlett** and **Covington & Burling**. **Nvidia / NVentures (Jensen Huang, Mohamed Siddeek):** Equity backer in OpenAI, xAI, Mistral, Cohere, Perplexity, Figure AI, CoreWeave; represented by **Cooley** and **Latham & Watkins**.

Amazon (Andy Jassy): \$4B into Anthropic; represented by **Gibson, Dunn & Crutcher**.

Google / Alphabet (Sundar Pichai): \$2B into Anthropic, Character.ai restructuring; represented by **Cleary Gottlieb** and **Wilson Sonsini**.

TIER 4: THE 4 LAW FIRMS EXCLUSIVELY STRUCTURING THE AI ECOSYSTEM

LAW FIRM	LEAD PARTNERS	KEY AI COMPANIES REPRESENTED	KEY AI VC FUNDS REPRESENTED
Cooley LLP cooley.com	Rachel Proffitt, Charlie Kim, Peter Werner, David Peinsipp	OpenAI (Corporate/IPO), Scale AI (\$13.8B), Perplexity , Mistral AI (US), SSI	Sequoia Capital, a16z, Index Ventures, NVentures, NFDG
Wilson Sonsini (WSGR) wsgr.com	Steven Bochner, Mark Baudler, Tony Jeffries, Allison Spinner	Anthropic (\$4B Amazon / \$2B Google / IPO prep), Astera Labs , Rubrik	Khosla Ventures, Menlo Ventures (Anthology Fund), Sequoia
Gunderson Dettmer gunder.com	Trevor Snider, Brian Patterson, Ivan Gaviria	Cognition AI (Devin), Cursor (Anysphere) , Harvey AI , Pika	a16z, Lightspeed, Founders Fund, Elad Gil, NFDG
Latham & Watkins lw.com	Marc Jaffe, Ian Schuman, Peter Handrinos	CoreWeave (\$1.1B equity / \$7.5B debt), Physical Intelligence	Coatue Management, Nvidia, Lead Banking Syndicates